

Active Oahu Tours — Onboarding Guide for Ella

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Welcome, Ella!

Aloha and welcome to Active Oahu Tours! We're so excited to have you join the team. This guide is designed to get you up to speed quickly and give you everything you need to start creating amazing content that shares the spirit of Oahu with the world. Take it at your own pace, and don't hesitate to ask questions — we're here to help you succeed.

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About Active Oahu Tours

Who We Are

Active Oahu Tours is a kayak tour and rental company based in beautiful Kailua, on the windward side of Oahu. We believe the best way to experience Hawaii is *on the water* — and our mission is to make Oahu's outdoors accessible to everyone, whether you're a seasoned paddler or stepping into a kayak for the first time.

What We Offer

- **Guided Kayak Tours** — Our bread and butter. Think Mokulua Islands, Chinaman's Hat, Kahana River, and the Kaneohe Bay sandbar.
- **E-Bike Adventures** — Exploring Oahu's scenic coastline on two wheels with a boost.
- **Paddleboarding** — Stand-up paddleboarding (SUP) rentals and guided sessions.

- **Beach Gear Rentals** — Everything visitors need for a perfect beach day (snorkel gear, umbrellas, chairs, coolers).

Our Digital Home

We're in the middle of a website migration, so here's what you need to know:

- **Current live site (WordPress):** activeoahutours.com — Hosted on Flywheel. This is where the WordPress CMS lives for now.
- **New static site (in progress):** active-oahu-tours-mirror.pages.dev — Built on Cloudflare Pages. This is where we're headed — a simpler, faster static site.
- **Booking system:** We use [FareHarbor](#) for all tour bookings (shortcode: activeoahutours).

The Competitive Landscape

Our main competitors on Oahu:

- **Kailua Beach Adventures** — Direct competitor in Kailua. Similar kayak tour offerings, well-established.
- **Kualoa Ranch** — Larger operation, famous for movie tours and ATV adventures. More of a “big attraction” feel — we're the local, personal alternative.

We differentiate by being *local, authentic, and approachable* — not a big-box tour operator.

Your Role

Position: Content Writer (Part-Time)

You'll be working remotely from Provo, UT while you finish up at BYU. We know you're juggling school and work, so we've designed this role to be flexible and realistic for a student schedule.

Core Responsibilities

Task	Frequency	What It Means
Blog posts	1-2 per week	Our main content engine. Drives SEO and gives visitors a reason to book.
Tour descriptions	As needed	Updating and polishing tour pages on the website and in FareHarbor.
Social media content	Ongoing	Captions, short-form content ideas, coordinating with any visual assets. Keeping past customers and

Email newsletters	1-2 per month	subscribers engaged with seasonal offers and stories.
Website content updates	As needed	Refreshing pages, adding new offerings, keeping everything accurate.
Local SEO support	Ongoing	Writing content that helps us rank for local search terms (e.g., “kayak tours Kailua,” “best things to do in Oahu”).
Review responses	Weekly	Responding to Google and FareHarbor reviews with our brand voice.

What Success Looks Like

- Consistent publishing cadence (blog posts, social content) that builds our online presence.
- Content that sounds like *us* — warm, knowledgeable, local-feeling, never corporate.
- Tour pages that are accurate, compelling, and convert browsers into bookers.
- A growing library of SEO-optimized content that brings organic traffic.

Tools & Access

Here’s everything you’ll need to get set up. Michael will get you access to each of these during your first week.

Essential Tools

Tool	What It’s For	Setup Needed
Google Docs	Content drafts, collaborative editing, outlines	Google account; shared folder invite
WordPress (Flywheel)	Current website CMS — editing pages, publishing blog posts	Login credentials from Michael
FareHarbor Dashboard	Managing tour descriptions in the booking system (shortcode: activeoahutours)	Dashboard access; Michael will add you as a user
Canva	Social media graphics, blog featured images, email headers	Free account is fine; team templates will be shared
	Brand assets, style	Invite to shared

Google Drive	guide, photo library, content calendar	folder from Michael
Slack or Discord	Team communication — daily check-ins during onboarding, then weekly	Michael will confirm which platform and invite you

Access Checklist

- ☐ Google Drive shared folder (brand assets, photos, style guide)
- ☐ WordPress login for activeoahutours.com
- ☐ FareHarbor dashboard access
- ☐ Canva team / template access
- ☐ Team chat (Slack or Discord) invite
- ☐ Content calendar (Google Sheets or similar)

Brand Voice & Style

This is the heart of what makes our content feel like *us*. Please internalize this and refer back to it often.

Our Voice At a Glance

Trait	What It Means	Do	Don't
Friendly	We sound like a knowledgeable local friend, not a tour brochure.	Use conversational language, contractions, "you" and "we."	Be stiff, formal, or use tourism clichés.
Local & Authentic	We know Oahu intimately and share real knowledge.	Mention specific landmarks, local tips, accurate tide/weather info.	Sound like a generic travel blog that could be about anywhere.
Respectful of Hawaiian Culture	We honor the land (ʻāina) and the people.	Use proper place names, acknowledge cultural significance, encourage respectful behavior.	Use Hawaiian words as decoration, misrepresent culture, or ignore the deeper meaning of places.
Adventure-Focused	We inspire people to get out there.	Use active verbs, paint vivid scenes, convey excitement.	Be reckless — always balance adventure with safety.
	We care about	Mention safety gear,	Ignore risks or

Safety-Conscious	our guests and their well-being.	conditions awareness, guide expertise.	downplay preparation.
Family-Friendly	Families with kids are a core audience.	Mention kid-friendly tours, age minimums, what to expect.	Use language that excludes families or is inappropriate for a broad audience.

Writing Tips

1. **Open with a hook** — A vivid scene, a surprising fact, or a relatable question.
2. **Keep paragraphs short** — 2–3 sentences max. Scannable content performs better.
3. **Use subheadings** — Break up long posts with clear, descriptive subheadings.
4. **Include a call to action** — Every blog post should naturally lead to “Book your tour today” or “Check availability.”
5. **Write for search, but for humans first** — Include relevant keywords naturally. Never stuff.
6. **Show, don’t just tell** — Instead of “the water is clear,” try “you can see the coral heads fifteen feet below your kayak.”

Words We Love

paddle · adventure · explore · island · ocean · reef · sunrise · trade winds · sandbar · sea turtles · coastline · hidden · local · authentic

Words We Avoid

luxury · exclusive · once-in-a-lifetime (it’s overused) · paradise (cliché) · magical · ultimate · world-class · bucket-list

Content Topics & Tour Knowledge

Tour Knowledge Base

Familiarize yourself with each of these. Read the current tour pages on the website first, then explore beyond.

Kayak Tours

Tour	Key Details	Content Angle
Mokulua Islands	Our signature tour. Two islets off Kailua Beach. Seabird sanctuary, tide pools, small beach landing.	Wildlife, the paddle out, what to bring, seasonal seabird nesting.
Chinaman’s Hat (Mokolii)	Iconic cone-shaped island off Kualoa. Short paddle,	Island folklore, views of Kualoa mountains, accessibility for

Kahana River	climbable summit. Calm river paddling through lush valley. Great for families and beginners.	beginners. Hawaiian history in Kahana Valley, flora, gentle pace, multi-generational appeal.
Kaneohe Bay Sandbar	Expansive sandbar that emerges at low tide. Postcard views of the Ko'olau mountains.	Tide timing, boat access, floating picnic vibes, photo ops.

E-Bike Adventures

- Coastal routes around Kailua and Lanikai.
- Scenic stops, photo ops, local food recommendations.
- Highlight the “e-bike advantage” — cover more ground without exhaustion, great for mixed-fitness groups.

Paddleboarding (SUP)

- Kailua Bay and the calmer waters of the canal.
- Beginner-friendly; emphasize stability and instruction.
- Morning sessions are best — calm winds, glassy water.

Beach Gear Rentals

- Practical: what’s included, pricing, delivery options.
- “Show up and we handle the rest” convenience angle.
- Perfect add-on for kayak tour customers.

Content Pillars (What to Write About)

1. **Tour Spotlights** — Deep dives on individual tours: what to expect, who it’s for, pro tips.
 2. **Local Knowledge** — Tides, weather patterns, best times to paddle, packing checklists.
 3. **Hawaiian Culture & ‘Āina** — Respectful content about place names, history, and responsible tourism.
 4. **Itineraries** — “How to spend a day in Kailua,” “Weekend adventure on the windward side.”
 5. **Comparisons & Guides** — “Kayaking vs. paddleboarding: which is right for you?” or “Kailua vs. Waikiki for kayaking.”
 6. **Customer Stories** — (With permission) Real guest experiences, photos, testimonials.
 7. **Seasonal Content** — Whale watching (winter), summer swell patterns, holiday gift guides.
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First Week Onboarding Plan

Here’s a day-by-day roadmap. It’s flexible — go at your own pace, and prioritize understanding over speed.

Day 1: Orientation & Reading

- ☐ Read this entire onboarding guide (you’re doing it now!).

- ☐ Read through the current website at activeoahutours.com — every page. Take notes on voice, offerings, and anything that seems outdated or unclear.
- ☐ Read at least 5 blog posts on the site to internalize the existing voice.
- ☐ Explore the new static site at active-oahu-tours-mirror.pages.dev — note what's different.
- ☐ Check in with Michael on Slack/Discord — brief intro, confirm you've started, ask any initial questions.

Day 2: Competitor Research

- ☐ Spend time on [Kailua Beach Adventures](#) — read their tour pages, blog, and About page. Note: what do they do well? Where do they feel weak or generic?
- ☐ Explore [Kualoa Ranch](#) — different scale, but understand their positioning.
- ☐ Write a one-page summary of your competitor observations (bullet points are fine). Share with Michael.
- ☐ Identify 3-5 content gaps — topics our competitors cover that we don't, or topics they cover *poorly* that we could do better.

Day 3: Content Calendar

- ☐ Get access to the content calendar (Google Sheets or similar) from Michael.
- ☐ Brainstorm 10+ blog post ideas based on your reading and competitor research.
- ☐ Draft a one-month content calendar:
 - 4-6 blog post titles with brief descriptions.
 - 2-3 social media content themes or series ideas.
 - 1 email newsletter topic.
- ☐ Share the draft calendar with Michael for feedback.

Day 4: First Blog Post

- ☐ Choose your first topic. Recommended starter: **“Why Kailua Beach Is Better Than Waikiki for Kayaking”** — or something similar that lets you show off local knowledge.
- ☐ Research: paddle conditions, launch spots, crowd comparisons, parking, vibe differences.
- ☐ Draft the post in Google Docs (1,200-1,800 words).
- ☐ Include: compelling headline, subheadings, at least one “local tip” callout, and a clear booking CTA.
- ☐ Share the draft with Michael for review.

Day 5: Wrap-Up & Setup Completion

- ☐ Confirm all tool access is working (see the [Access Checklist](#)).
 - ☐ Browse the Google Drive brand asset folder — get familiar with logos, photos, and any existing style guides.
 - ☐ Review the Canva templates available for social media and blog graphics.
 - ☐ Send Michael a brief end-of-week summary: what you learned, what you're excited about, any questions or blockers.
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Practical Details

Schedule & Communication

- **Hours:** Part-time, flexible around your BYU class schedule. Exact hours and pay rate will be finalized with Michael.
- **Check-ins:** Daily during your first week (quick Slack/Discord message — what you worked on, any questions). After onboarding, weekly check-ins are fine.
- **Availability:** We don't expect instant responses — but please respond within 24 hours on weekdays.

Turnaround Expectations

Content Type	Expected Turnaround
Blog post (1,200–1,800 words)	2–3 days from assignment to first draft
Shorter content (social captions, tour descriptions, email copy)	1–2 days
Revisions	Within 1 day of receiving feedback

Who to Contact

- **Michael** — Your main point of contact. Content direction, feedback, access issues, scheduling, pay. Reach him on Slack/Discord.
- **Team chat** — For general questions, ideas, or quick input from the rest of the team.

Working Remotely (Provo → Oahu)

- Hawaii is 4 hours behind Mountain Time during daylight saving (spring/summer), and 3 hours behind during standard time (fall/winter). Keep time zones in mind when expecting responses.
- All content work is async — write on your schedule, share drafts, receive feedback. No real-time meetings unless explicitly scheduled.

Onboarding Checklist

Use this as your master checklist. Check things off as you go.

Setup & Access

- ☐ Google Drive shared folder invite accepted
- ☐ WordPress login received and tested
- ☐ FareHarbor dashboard access working
- ☐ Canva account set up / team access granted
- ☐ Team chat (Slack or Discord) joined
- ☐ Content calendar access granted

Learning & Research

- ☐ Read entire onboarding guide
- ☐ Read every page on activeoahutours.com
- ☐ Read 5+ existing blog posts
- ☐ Reviewed new static site on Cloudflare Pages
- ☐ Completed competitor analysis (Kailua Beach Adventures + Kualoa Ranch)
- ☐ Shared competitor observations with Michael

Content Creation

- ☐ Brainstormed 10+ blog post ideas
- ☐ Drafted one-month content calendar
- ☐ Shared content calendar with Michael for feedback
- ☐ Written and submitted first blog post draft
- ☐ Incorporated first-round feedback

Wrap-Up

- ☐ All tools confirmed working
 - ☐ Familiar with Google Drive brand assets
 - ☐ Familiar with Canva templates
 - ☐ Sent end-of-week summary to Michael
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Quick Reference

Important Links

Resource	URL
Live Website (WordPress)	activeoahutours.com
New Static Site	active-oahu-tours-mirror.pages.dev
FareHarbor Dashboard	fareharbor.com (shortname: activeoahutours)
Competitor: Kailua Beach Adventures	kailuabeachadventures.com
Competitor: Kualoa Ranch	kualoaranch.com

Quick Do's and Don'ts

Do: - Write like a knowledgeable local friend - Use specific place names and details - Mention safety and preparation - Include clear calls to action - Respect Hawaiian culture and language - Check tide charts and conditions when writing about water activities

Don't: - Sound like a corporate travel brochure - Use generic tourism clichés ("paradise," "bucket list," "once in a lifetime") - Ignore cultural context - Overpromise or exaggerate - Neglect safety information - Use Hawaiian words as decoration without understanding them

Mahalo for reading, Ella. We're genuinely excited to have you on the team. Your writing is going to help share the real Oahu — the one locals know and love — with adventurers from all over the world. Let's make something great together.

— Michael & the Active Oahu Tours Team